

ISSUE
03
JUNE 2024



KAIROS

A STORY OF TIME. A WAR OF TRUTH.

WRITTEN &
ILLUSTRATED BY
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IN A WORLD
BUILT ON LIES,
THE TRUTH
IS A SIN.

AND MEMORY—
THE ULTIMATE
WEAPON.

03:
The
Weight
of a
True Thing

—
本当のものの重さ

KAI MORI

森 海

HE REMEMBERED.
NOW HE PAYS.



5:50 A.M.

THE SCHOOL'S
COVERED
BICYCLE SHED,
GREY PRE-DAWN
LIGHT.

THE ONLY
SOUND IN
THE WORLD
IS THE ROOF
DRIPPING.

EVERY SADDLE
HOLDS DEW.

EVERYTHING
ELSE HOLDS
ITS BREATH.

KAI MORI,
17.

THE READER
OF PRESENT
TRUTH.

LAST NIGHT,
I BURIED
THE SECOND
TRUTH.

NAKA.

I DID NOT
LET IT
SURFACE.

I MADE
A CHOICE.

QUIET.
DELIBERATE.
FINAL.

AND NOW,
THERE IS
NOWHERE
TO PUT THE
LEFTOVER
WEIGHT.

MY EYES
DO THE
CALCULATING.

BUT MY
BODY
BETRAYS
EVERYTHING.

THE ROOF
DRIPS.
THAT IS
ALL.

I HAVEN'T
SLEPT.
MY
SHOULDERS
AREN'T
RIGHT.
MY WEIGHT
IS WRONG.
I STAND
LIKE A
PUPPET.

THIS IS
NOT THE WAY
TO THE GATE.

NOT THE WAY
HOME.

JUST THE
FIRST PLACE
MY FEET
FOUND.

I WEAR
ARROGANCE
LIKE A MASK.

BUT UNDER IT,
I CAN FEEL
THE EDGE.

I AM LOSING
MY MIND.

THE SHED
IS EMPTY.

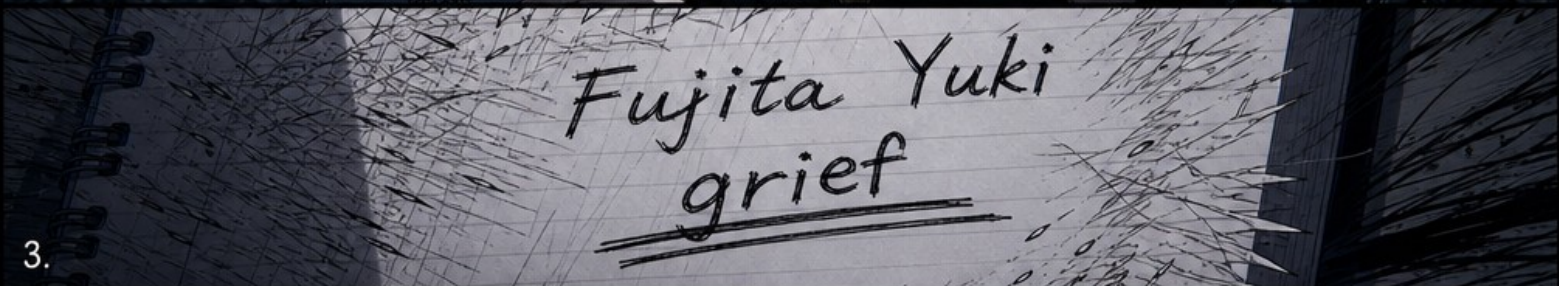
THE SILENCE
IS HEAVY.

JUST LIKE
WHAT I DID.

NO ONE
KNOWS.

NOT YET.

NOT TODAY.



SHOE LOCKER ROOM

7:55 AM

MORNING
CHURN.
ORDINARY.
OBLIVIOUS.



FUJITA YUKI. 16.

FIRST-YEAR.
QUIET.
UNREMARKABLE.



SHE MOVES
WITH CARE
THROUGH
CROWDED
ROOMS.
NEVER QUITE
NOTICED.

KAI MORI. 17.

HE DOES NOT
LOOK.
HE DOES NOT
READ.

HIS GIFT CATCHES
WHAT IS TRUE—
ANYWAY.



CONTROLLED GRIEF
BEHIND ORDINARY
MORNING FACE.



RENT MONEY
COUNTED TWICE.



FAMILY PHOTO.
ONE PARENT ABSENT
FROM RECENT FRAMES.



A FLICKER.
NOT INTENTIONAL.



HIS STEP
FALTERS
BY HALF
A BEAT.



THEN HE
CONTINUES.
AS ALWAYS.



SHE DOES
NOT NOTICE.



THE MORNING
MOVES ON.
LOUD.
OBLIVIOUS.
UNCARING.



EPISODE 3: THE WEIGHT OF PRIORITY

STUDENT COUNCIL OFFICE
MID-MORNING

THE SHELVES
STILL SHOW
THE GAPS—
EPISODE 2'S
CONFISCATION.

1

HER BARE HAND HOVERS
ABOVE THE DRAWER'S
PULL-HANDLE—
WORN SMOOTH BY
NAKA'S OWN GRIP
OVER MONTHS.

REIKA TENDO
STUDENT COUNCIL PRESIDENT
18 YEARS OLD

NAKA'S DESK.
HIS ABSENCE.
MY RESPONSIBILITY.

2

CONTACT—
AND THE PAST
FLOODS IN.

NAKA. CASH.
THE ENVELOPE.
A DOOR CHECKED
TWICE.

THE TIGHT RELIEF
OF SOMEONE
WHO JUST DID
SOMETHING THAT
COSTS HIM—
AND HELPS
SOMEONE ELSE.

3

HER BREATH CATCHES.
THE VISION SHARPENS.

THE ENVELOPE'S DESTINATION—
NOT HIMSELF.

SOMEONE ELSE.

A NAME SHE CANNOT
YET MAKE OUT.

4

SHE WITHDRAWS.
THE VISION
SNAPS SHUT
BEFORE THE
NAME RESOLVES.

HER COMPOSURE
FRACTURES—
FOR A MOMENT.

SHE UNDERSTANDS,
BEFORE SHE
UNDERSTANDS
ANYTHING ELSE—
**THE CASE
IS NOT
FINISHED.**

HER ARMOR OF PERFECTION, MOMENTARILY EXPOSED—
THE BURDEN SHE CARRIES, VISIBLY HEAVIER THAN BEFORE.





I'VE BEEN
WATCHING
SINCE
EPISODE 2.

SAME
BENCH.
SAME ANGLE.
SAME JOB.

PRESENT
WITHOUT
REGISTERING
AS PRESENT.

TODAY,
THE WEIGHT
ISN'T AIMED
AT KAI.

IT'S NOT
NAKA'S CASE
EITHER.

IT'S...DIFFUSE.
GATHERING.
WITHOUT A
FACE YET.

CONSEQUENCE-DREAD.

A HUM THAT
DOESN'T HAVE
A NAME YET.

I DON'T KNOW
WHO IT'S
AIMED AT.

BUT IT'S
MOVING.



MY GIFT
FINDS
BEFORE
MY MIND
CATCHES
UP.

I DON'T
CHOOSE
THE
DIRECTION.



IT JUST
BENDS.

TUGS.

PULLS
MY LINE OF
SIGHT.

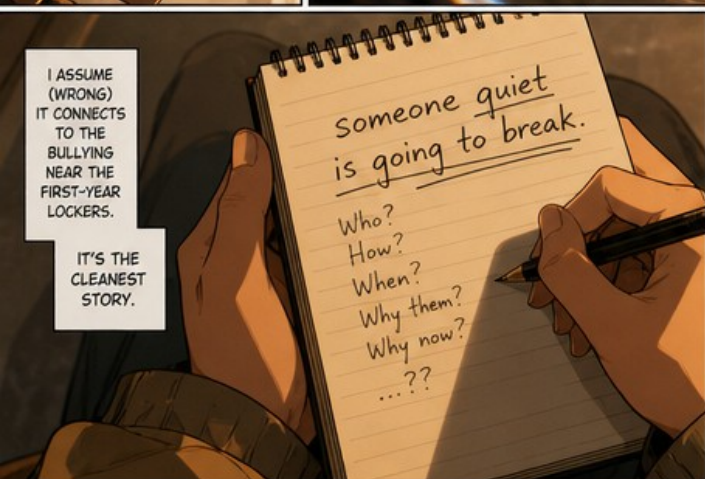
TOWARD
THE SHOE
LOCKERS.

TOWARD
FUJITA YUKI'S
HOMEROOM
DOOR.



NOTHING
THERE
YET.

BUT
SOMETHING
WILL BE.



I ASSUME
(WRONG)
IT CONNECTS
TO THE
BULLYING
NEAR THE
FIRST-YEAR
LOCKERS.

IT'S THE
CLEANEST
STORY.

Someone quiet
is going to break.

Who?
How?
When?
Why them?
Why now?
...??



I WRITE
WHAT I CAN
WITHOUT
KNOWING
WHO.

UNCERTAIN.
INCOMPLETE.
TRUE.

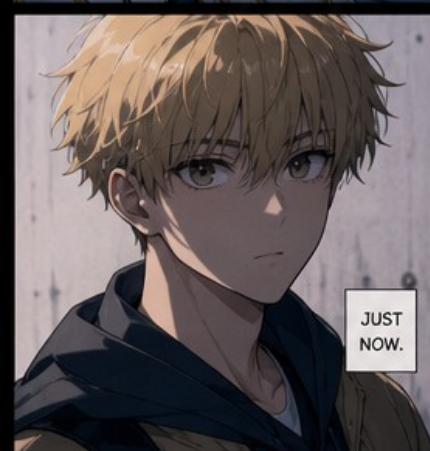


THE RULE
I CAN'T BREAK
(AND WON'T):

I DON'T
INTERVENE
ON SHADOW.

I CATALOG.
I WAIT.

I HOPE
I'M NOT
TOO LATE.





THE FIRE ESCAPE,
CONTINUOUS.

AN ENVELOPE.

A DESTINATION
I COULDN'T READ.

A COST I CAN FEEL,
BUT NOT YET NAME.

SORA MINABE, 16.

SOMEONE QUIET
IS GOING TO
BREAK.



KAI MORI HAS ALREADY
READ IT IN FULL.
AND BURIED IT.

I HAVEN'T FOUND
ANYTHING WORTH
SHARING YET.

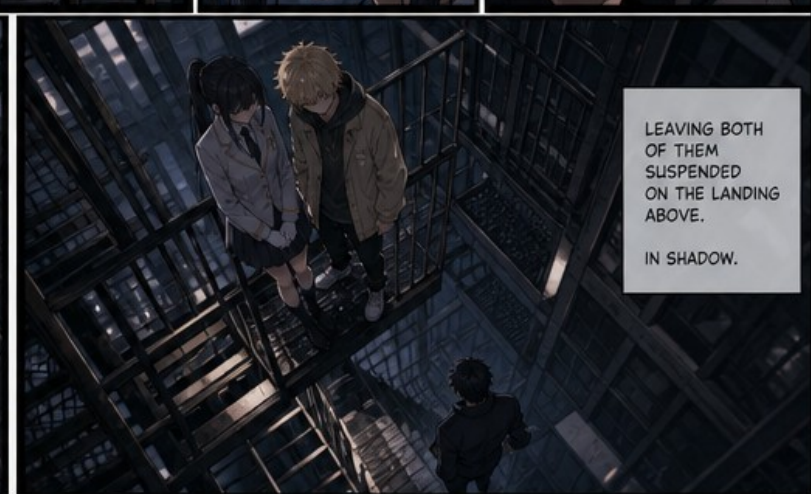
THE FIRST
DELIBERATE LIE.



HE TURNS ABRUPTLY.

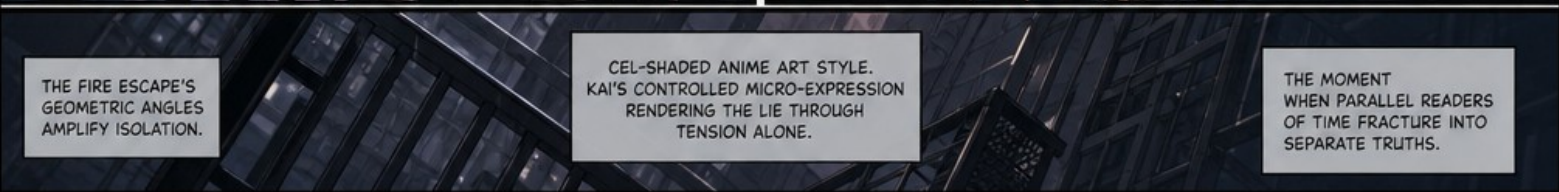
HANDS SHOVED DEEP
INTO HIS POCKETS.

DESCENDING THE
NARROW METAL STAIRS
ALONE.



LEAVING BOTH
OF THEM
SUSPENDED
ON THE LANDING
ABOVE.

IN SHADOW.



THE FIRE ESCAPE'S
GEOMETRIC ANGLES
AMPLIFY ISOLATION.

CEL-SHADED ANIME ART STYLE.
KAI'S CONTROLLED MICRO-EXPRESSION
RENDERING THE LIE THROUGH
TENSION ALONE.

THE MOMENT
WHEN PARALLEL READERS
OF TIME FRACTURE INTO
SEPARATE TRUTHS.

CHAPTER 37
WELL-INTENTIONED
SILENCE

KAI MORI, 17
REFERRED BY
FUJIWARA-SENSEI
AFTER OBSERVED
INSTABILITY IN
FOURTH PERIOD.

Good Study
Habits

Small Steps, Big Results



COUNSELING
SUPPORTS
STUDENTS



TICK.
TICK.

THE ONLY SOUND.
AN OLD CLOCK'S
SECOND HAND.

I WILL SAY
THE RIGHT
THINGS.

I WILL
PERFORM
CALM.
FOR THEM.

COUNSELING
OFFICE

IN HERE,
I AM ALREADY
A DIAGNOSIS
LOOKING FOR
A SYMPTOM.

STUDENT WELL-BEING REFERRAL

Student Name: Kai Mori

Referred by: Fujiwara-sensei

Reason for Referral:

Observed swaying / unsteadiness
in class. Appears fatigued.

Possible Factors:

- ☐ Stress
- ☒ Sleep Hygiene
- ☐ Anxiety
- ☐ Other

Notes:

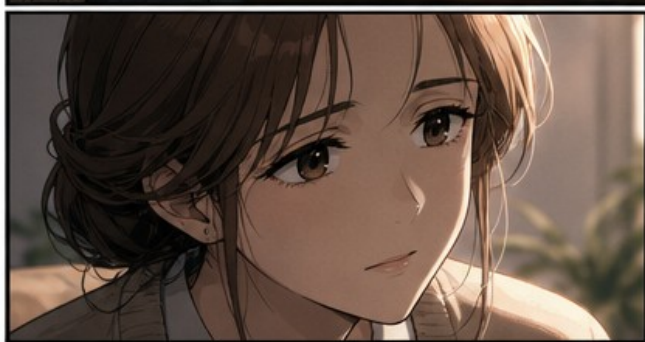
Recommend counseling session
Monitor and follow up.

STRESS.
SLEEP HYGIENE.
FOLLOW UP.

FILED.
NOT SOLVED.

THEY MEAN
WELL.
THAT IS WHAT
MAKES IT
HARDER.

WHATEVER
I SAY NEXT
WILL FOLLOW
ANYWAY.







SAYS THE TOUGHEST
CHOICES DON'T
HAPPEN IN COURTROOMS.

THEY HAPPEN HERE.

ON QUIET CORNERS.
UNDER UGLY LIGHTS.
OVER SOMETHING
AS STUPID AS A
VENDING MACHINE CAN.

IT WOULD HELP
NO ONE.

IT WOULD ONLY
EXPOSE A GIRL'S
PRIVATE SHAME TO
SATISFY SOMETHING
UGLY IN ME.

CLUNK

THE SAME URGE
THAT FELT, IN
EPISODE 2,

UNCOMFORTABLY
LIKE POWER.

I COULD SURFACE
FUJITA'S FAMILY
TRUTH.

I COULD WATCH
THE WORLD
SHIFT.

BUT WHY?

SHE'S ALREADY
CARRYING
ENOUGH.

I DON'T NEED
TO ADD TO IT.

THIS ISN'T
JUST A DECISION.

IT'S A
LINE I DON'T
CROSS.

psst

SILENCE IS
SOMETIMES THE
ONLY MERCY
YOU GET TO
CHOOSE.

DECISION MADE.
NOT IN GLORY.
JUST HERE.
JUST NOW.

MASTER LOCATION POOL SITE:
FLOOD CHANNEL UNDERPASS

3:17 A.M.

KAI MORI.
CLASS 2-7.
FUTURE VALUE:
UNRELIABLE.

HE
DOESN'T
KNOW
I'M
HERE.

SUBJECTIVE POV

CALIBRATING
UNCERTAINTY...

FILTERING
NOISE...

FOCUS
LOCKED.

NOT DANGER.
CHOICE.
AND IT WILL
COST HIM
LATER.

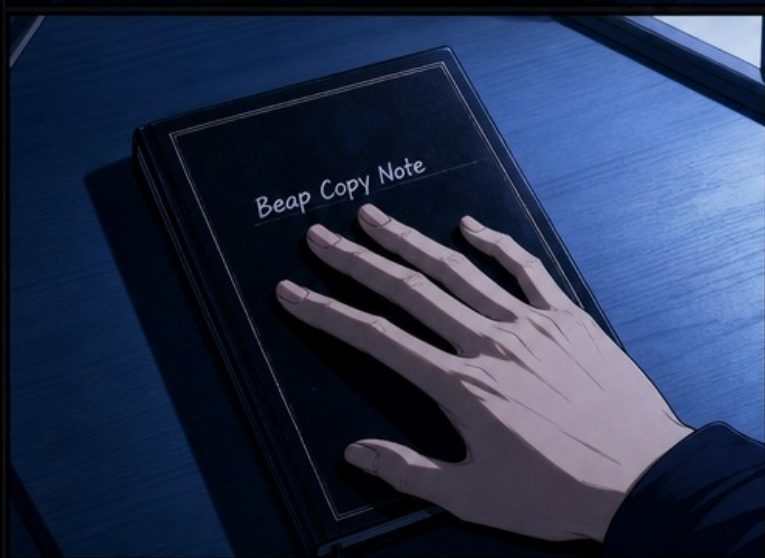
he decided something.
I don't know if it was
the right one.

THE CAN
HITS METAL.
THE SOUND
TRAVELS.
FARTHER
THAN IT
SHOULD.

CLUNK³

HE'S
DECIDING
SOMETHING
RIGHT NOW.

TODAY.





1.

The notebook vibrated.
His hand recoiled half an inch.



2.

The cover eased open on its own.
No fugue.
No hijacked hand.
It opened itself.



3.

A name.
Three words.
His grandfather.



4.

His hand slammed the cover shut.
The lamp rattled.
The silence broke.



It had never asked before.
Now it was choosing what to say.



CUT TO BLACK.